

CDN Incident Alert: 105. TLP: CLEAR		Date
Title	MD Propaganda Schizophrenia – The Kremlin Invents a New Mental Illness for Maia Sandu	10/10/2025

Summary

- A Russian-aligned influence network launched a disinformation campaign falsely claiming that Moldovan President Maia Sandu suffers from schizophrenia, supported by forged documents allegedly issued by Döbling Clinic in Vienna.
- The incident undermines public trust in Moldova's democratic institutions by weaponising false medical claims to discredit the president and stigmatise mental health.
- The narrative aimed to portray Sandu as mentally unstable and unfit to govern, echoing misogynistic tropes and exploiting stigma around mental health.
- The fabricated report was disseminated through Gagauznews website Telegram channels such as Молдавская политика - @mold_politika (now Свободная Молдова) and Win/Win (@victorstepanych), later republished by two Czech-language websites, and further promoted by anonymous accounts on Facebook, X, Instagram, and TikTok. Impact: approximately 72.4 million combined views before being debunked.
- The operation reused an identical fake from 2024, combining gendered and medical disinformation tactics to defame a pro-European leader ahead of the 2025 parliamentary elections and polarise Moldovan society.
- Recommendations include strengthening rapid response communication and ensuring platform terms of use enforcement on coordinated inauthentic behaviour.

Incident

On 5 September 2025, the Russian-aligned outlet Gagauznews (www[.]gagauznews[.]com) [published](#) a fabricated story claiming that Moldovan President Maia Sandu was diagnosed with schizophrenia at the Döbling Private Clinic in Vienna - debunked by [StopFals.md](#) on 5 September 2025. The post contained a forged medical certificate bearing the falsified signature of a real Austrian physician. The campaign recycled a 2024 [disinformation episode](#), which had also used the Döbling Clinic's name and signature to fabricate medical records. The [forgery was](#) initially debunked by StopFals.md in 2024, which contacted the Döbling Clinic's International Relations Department. The clinic's representative, Sonja Fürnsinn, [officially denied](#) the authenticity of both the document and the signature, confirming that the alleged report was never issued by their institution and that its content was grammatically incorrect and inconsistent with the clinic's medical standards.

The initial post was amplified through pro-Russian Telegram channels (@gagauznewsmd, @danielmikusekpolska; @lipca11; @Pozyteczne_Smiglo; @cz24news; @Bielsk_Podlaski; @mold_politika; @victorstepanych, etc.), Pravda network (Pravda auf Deutsch; Pravda Moldova; World – Pravda EN; Pravda România; Pravda Austria, Bulgaria Pravda) and anonymous social-media accounts on Facebook (Сергей Добровольский; Игорь Олегович Сарапкин; Ilie Larisa, etc.), X (@saa1099770; @best_fisher; @ps_trump; @ggosebrecht; @shenja553042; @StapelAndrew; @EstulinVz; @ncostrus, etc.), Instagram (gagauznews), VK (mydayn; id466695329; russ.derzhava, etc.), YouTube and TikTok (@abdrey.mir577). Analysis of posting times, identical phrasing across languages, synchronized reposts within minutes, and shared media assets (the same forged medical certificate image and identical hashtags) indicate coordinated, centrally directed amplification rather than organic user engagement. The target audience included Moldovan voters, particularly in Russian-speaking and Gagauz communities, where anti-Western sentiment is routinely cultivated. The narrative aimed to portray Sandu as mentally unstable and unfit to govern, echoing misogynistic tropes and exploiting stigma around mental health. The motivation appears twofold: first, to erode domestic trust in Sandu's leadership ahead of elections, and second to discredit her internationally as a "Western puppet."

In October 2025, during [a defamation trial](#), a defence lawyer requested that President Maia Sandu undergo a psychiatric evaluation - an attempt widely seen as an effort to revive the false "mental illness" narrative launched by pro-Russian outlets. The Chişinău Court dismissed the request as unfounded, showing how digital disinformation can extend into judicial spaces to erode trust in democratic institutions.

Systemic Violation Assessment

This incident undermines public trust in Moldova's democratic institutions by weaponising false medical claims to discredit the president and stigmatise mental health. Timed before the parliamentary elections, it distorts voter perception, fuels polarisation, and erodes confidence in the integrity of the electoral process. The incident involves

both content violations (fabricated medical disinformation, identity-based harassment) and behavioural violations (coordinated amplification via anonymous accounts).
This incident outlines a violation of **national law (defamation, document forgery)** and **platform terms of service** related to *Coordinated Inauthentic Behaviour* (CIB) and *Manipulated Media*.

Narrative

Meta narrative: The West promotes corrupt and mentally unstable leaders to control Eastern Europe.
Sub-narratives: - Maia Sandu is mentally ill and unfit to govern; Female leaders are emotionally unstable and manipulated by foreign powers; Western institutions protect and hide the truth; The West exports moral decay to Moldova; Pro-European politics equals hypocrisy and deception.

Impact

Reach: estimated over 72.4 million total views across websites, Telegram and social media; shared by at least 500 anonymous or pseudonymous accounts.
Outcome:
– Official denial from Döbling Clinic and the Moldovan Presidency;
– Fact-checks by Stopfals.md;
– Partial takedowns by Meta and X following reports;
– Court dismissed attempt to revive the false narrative.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective 1: [T0135.004: Polarise](#): The operation amplifies divisive narratives portraying Moldova’s pro-European leadership as morally corrupt and mentally unstable, with the intent to fracture society along ideological, linguistic, and gender lines.
[T0140.001: Defame](#): By fabricating a psychiatric diagnosis and forging medical documents, threat actors seek to destroy Maia Sandu’s public image and credibility, eroding trust in democratic institutions and Western partners.
[T0140.003: Spread Hate](#): The campaign exploits sexist and anti-Western sentiments, encouraging mockery, moral outrage, and social exclusion of women in politics through the rhetoric of “madness” and “weakness.”
[T0084: Reuse Existing Content](#): Actors recycled and modified a previously debunked 2024 falsehood, adapting it to the 2025 electoral context to renew attention and legitimacy while saving operational resources.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions Taken: N/A
Recommendations:
– Continue monitoring pro-Kremlin networks in Gagauzia and Russian Telegram spaces by StratCom Moldova and civil society organisations with international partners;
– Conduct proactive gendered disinformation awareness campaigns by civil society organisations and fact-checking groups, in partnership with the Moldovan government’s equality bodies and international partners like the EU and UN Women;
– Encourage platforms to improve detection of reused disinformation assets by national regulators in coordination with EU digital policy bodies;
– Coordinate transnational counter-narratives during Moldovan elections.

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	FIMI Assessment
N/A	Russia.	Upon Request	Nicolae Țîbrigan & Dragoș Sorescu (Digital Forensic Team), Counter Disinformation Network team	Facebook, Telegram, Instagram, TikTok	X, High Certainty